F9CC04 — DESIGN AND IMAGING SOFTWARE

Image Editing & Graphic Creation

Day 2 · Hands On in the Software

RECAP ACTIVITY

Vector or Raster?

I'm going to show you a series of images on screen.
Type V for Vector or R for Raster in the chat before I reveal the answer.

How to play

1. I show an image or description on screen
2. You type V or R in the chat — commit to your answer before I reveal
3. I click to reveal the answer and we talk through why
4. There are 8 rounds — your score is on screen

FOUNDATION CONCEPT

Vector vs Raster — The Full Picture

VECTOR

Mathematical paths and curves

Scales to any size — no quality loss whatsoever

Logos, icons, illustrations, diagrams

Save working file as: .ai or .svg

Export final as: .eps or .pdf

Software: Illustrator • Inkscape • Affinity Designer

RASTER

A fixed grid of pixels

Scale up past original size = blurry and pixelated

Photographs, textures, complex images

Save working file as: .psd

Export final as: .jpg .png .tiff

Software: Photoshop • GIMP • Photopea

The workflow: Vector and Raster files are combined in a Desktop Publishing tool (Canva, InDesign) to produce the final design.

DAY 2 — SCHEDULE

Today's Plan

9:30	Recap — Vector vs Raster quiz
10:00	Technical factors — resolution, colour modes, canvas setup
11:00	Break
11:15	DEMO — Photopea: document setup and photo editing
12:00	Lunch
13:00	Practical — edit your own image for your brief
13:45	Font and colour share in the chat
14:00	DEMO — Typography and creating graphic elements
14:45	Practical — build your graphic elements
15:30	Workbook writing — P2, P4, K6
16:15	Wrap-up

Three Decisions That Shape Everything

Make these before you open the software. Getting them wrong at the start means problems you cannot fix at the end.

Resolution

How much detail is packed into each inch of your image. 72dpi for screens and social media. 300dpi for commercial print. Use the wrong one and your print job will be rejected or your file will be unnecessarily huge.

Colour Mode

RGB for anything displayed on a screen — monitors, phones, social media. CMYK for anything that goes to a commercial printer. Mixing these up causes colours to shift in ways you cannot predict and often cannot fix.

Canvas Size

The exact dimensions of your document. A5 for your flyer. 1080×1920px for your Instagram story. Set this before you start — resizing a document after you have built your design is painful and often distorts your work.

Resolution

Resolution = how much detail is packed into each inch of an image. Measured in DPI (dots per inch) for print, PPI (pixels per inch) for screens. In practice, designers use both terms interchangeably.

72 DPI

Screen & Social Media

→ Standard for all digital screens and phones

→ Small file size means fast loading on web

→ Never use for print — it will look blurry and pixelated

→ Your Instagram story: 1080 × 1920px at 72dpi

150 DPI

Low-quality print only

→ Minimum for some basic print applications

→ Newspapers sometimes accept this resolution

→ Still not ideal — not recommended for your brief

→ Avoid unless you have no other option

300 DPI

Commercial Print

→ Industry standard for all commercial print work

→ Your A5 flyer must be 300dpi — no exceptions

→ File sizes are larger — this is expected and correct

→ Anything below 300dpi will be rejected by a print shop

Colour Modes

RGB

Red, Green, Blue

Used for	Screens, social media, websites, apps, TV
How it works	Mixes light — all three at full brightness creates white
Your project	Instagram story, any web or social media output
File formats	JPEG, PNG, GIF, PSD (screen version)
Software	Photopea, GIMP, most tools default to RGB

CMYK

Cyan, Magenta, Yellow, Key (Black)

Used for	Commercial print — flyers, posters, packaging, press
How it works	Mixes ink — all four at full strength creates near-black
Your project	A5 flyer sent to a commercial printer
File formats	TIFF, print-ready PDF, AI, INDD
Software	Photoshop and Affinity Photo only — full CMYK support

Document Setup — Your Exact Settings

Write these down. You will use them when we set up documents in the demo.

A5 Flyer — Print

Width	148 mm
Height	210 mm
Resolution	300 DPI
Colour Mode	RGB (Canva) or CMYK (Photoshop)
Bleed	Add 3mm each side — extended to 154 × 216mm

Instagram Story — Social

Width	1080 px
Height	1920 px
Resolution	72 PPI
Colour Mode	RGB
Safe Zone	Keep key content 250px from top and bottom edges

DEMO

Photopea — Document Setup & Photo Editing

Watch first — hands off your keyboard. Your turn comes straight after.

1. Open photopea.com — new document at A5, 300dpi
2. Tour the interface — tools, layers panel, properties
3. Open and place an image — resize using transform handles
4. Crop tool — reframe using rule of thirds
5. Adjustment layers — brightness, levels, hue and saturation
6. Add a text layer — font choice, size, colour
7. Save as .psd — export as .jpg and .png

KEY CONCEPT

Understanding Layers

Layers are the most important concept in any image editing software. Get this right and everything else becomes manageable.

- Top element
- Text
- Shapes
- Photography
- Background

Name every layer

Double-click a layer name to rename it. Layer 1, Layer 2 tells you nothing. Hero image, Brand name, Background colour tells you everything. This becomes critical when a file has 40 layers.

Layer order is visual order

The layer at the top of the stack sits on top visually. Drag layers up and down to change what appears in front.

Use adjustment layers

For colour changes, always use a dedicated Adjustment Layer. It sits above the image and can be removed or changed without altering the original pixel data beneath.

Group related layers

Select several layers and press Ctrl+G to group them. Name the group. Header elements, Background, Logo. Keeps complex files navigable.

REFERENCE — KEEP THIS VISIBLE

Your Core Toolkit Today

V — **Move Tool**

Select and reposition any layer. Hold Shift to constrain to horizontal or vertical.

C — **Crop Tool**

Trim and reframe. Turn on the rule of thirds overlay to guide your composition.

M / L — **Marquee / Lasso**

Select a region. Marquee for precise rectangles. Lasso for freehand selection.

W — **Magic Wand**

Select areas of similar colour — useful for isolating subjects on plain backgrounds.

T — **Text Tool**

Click to place a text box. Font panel appears in the top toolbar. Each text element gets its own layer.

Layers panel — **Adjustment Layers**

Non-destructive colour edits. Always use these — never adjust directly on the image.

File > Export — **Crop → Export**

Export as JPEG for web and print. PNG for transparent backgrounds. Always keep your PSD.

Ctrl + T — **Transform**

Resize, rotate, and reposition any selected layer. Hold Shift to preserve proportions.

DEMO

Typography & Graphic Elements

Watch first. Then build the graphic elements for your own brief.

1. Font pairing live — display font plus body font, explained
2. Build hierarchy — headline, subheading, body at three sizes
3. Create a colour shape — banner, block, or overlay
4. Layer order and transparency — shape behind text
5. Alignment tools — nothing placed randomly
6. Group and label your layers
7. Export a PNG with a transparent background

YOUR TURN — 13:00

Edit Your Hero Image

Everything in this task maps directly to P6 in your workbook. Screenshot after each step.

1

Set up and place

New document, A5 at 300dpi. Open and place your hero image. Resize to fill the canvas using transform. Screenshot.

2

Select your subject

Use Quick Select or Object Selection to isolate your main subject. Try both tools. Screenshot each one with a caption naming the tool.

3

Adjust the image

Add adjustment layers in this order: Brightness/Contrast → Levels → Hue/Saturation. Screenshot each layer in the layers panel.

4

Save both versions

Save PSD (working file). Export JPEG at full size for print. Resize to 650px wide and export again for web. Screenshot both exports.

AFTERNOON PRACTICAL

Build Your Brief Graphics

Everything you create now feeds directly into your final flyer and Instagram story tomorrow. Screenshot each stage as you go.

1

Edit your hero image

Import an image from Pexels that fits your brand. Crop, adjust levels and hue. Save as PSD, export as JPEG.

2

Build your headline

Brand name in your display font. Subheading in your body font. Three text sizes showing clear hierarchy.

3

Create a colour element

A shape, banner, or background block using your brand palette. Be ready to explain why it is positioned where it is.

4

Screenshot everything

A screenshot after each step goes into your P6 workbook section. Caption each one with what you did and why.

3:30PM — WORKBOOK WRITING

Converting Your Work Into Evidence

Open F9CC04_Students_Answers. These are the sections you are completing today. Write in full sentences — not bullet points.

P2	Three separate paragraphs. One on vector software — what it is, when you use it, what file formats it produces. One on raster software. One on DTP software. Each paragraph should be four to six sentences. Screenshot each software tool and caption it.
P4	A paragraph on design principles covering emphasis, balance, composition, typography and alignment. Then your font section — name your fonts, explain why you chose them, what mood they create, and how they match your brand. Screenshot your typography work from today.
K6	Technical factors for both web and print. For web: low resolution for download speed, RGB colour mode, accessibility considerations. For print: 300dpi resolution, CMYK colour mode, bleed, font embedding. Write each as a full explanatory sentence, not a list.

END OF DAY 2

What you covered today

- Vector vs Raster — the concept that underpins every software decision
- Resolution, colour modes and canvas setup — technical foundations for K6
- Photopea — document setup, layers, photo editing and colour adjustments
- Typography in software — font pairing and visual hierarchy
- Graphic elements — shapes, colour, grouping and alignment
- P2, P4 and K6 workbook sections — converted today's work into evidence

Tomorrow: pull everything together in your final designs.